

RHODODENDRON

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Azalea, rhododendron

ERICACEAE

Large genus of over 1,000 species of evergreen, semievergreen, or deciduous shrubs, ranging in habit from dwarf to treelike, and grown mainly for their spectacular, sometimes strongly scented flowers. Fully hardy to frost tender. Most prefer dappled shade, but a considerable number tolerate full sun, especially in cool climates. Need neutral to acidic soil—ideally, humus-rich and well-drained. Shallow planting is essential, as plants are surface-rooting. Deadhead spent flowers, wherever practical, to encourage energy into growth rather than seed production. Propagate by layering or semiripe cuttings in late summer. Yellowing leaves are usually caused by poor drainage, excessively deep planting, or lime in soil. Weevils and powdery mildew may also cause problems. ①The nectar of some rhododendron flowers may cause severe discomfort if ingested. See also feature panel pp.124–25.

Rhododendrons and azaleas

The genus *Rhododendron* includes not only evergreen, large-leaved and frequently large-flowered species and hybrids, but also dwarf, smaller-leaved shrubs, both evergreen and deciduous, with few-flowered clusters of usually small blooms. “Azalea” is the common name given to the deciduous species and hybrids, as well as to a group of compact, evergreen shrubs derived mainly from Japanese species. They are valued for their abundant, small, colorful blooms produced in late spring. Many of the evergreen azaleas (sometimes known as Belgian azaleas) may also be grown as house plants. Botanically, however, all are classified as *Rhododendron*. The flowers are usually single, but may be semidouble or double, including hose-in-hose (one flower tube inside the other). Unless otherwise stated below, flowers are single and leaves mid- to dark green and ovate.

R. aberconwayi. Evergreen, distinctly erect rhododendron. H to 8ft (2.5m), S 4ft (1.2m). Has small, broadly lance-shaped, rigid, deep green leaves. Bears saucer-shaped, white flowers in late spring. Z5–9
R. albrechtii. Deciduous, upright, bushy azalea. H to 10ft (3m), S 6ft (2m). Has spoon-shaped leaves, clustered at branch tips, and, in spring, bears loose clusters of 3–5 bell-shaped, green-spotted, purple or pink flowers. Z6–8
R. ‘Alison Johnstone’. Evergreen, bushy, compact rhododendron. H and S 6ft (2m). Produces an abundance of exquisite, bell-shaped, peach-pink flowers in spring and has waxy, gray-green leaves. Z7–9
R. ‘Angelo’. Evergreen, bushy rhododendron. H and S to 12ft (4m). Has bold foliage and large, fragrant, funnel-shaped, pinkish-white flowers in midsummer. Good in light woodland. Z7–9
R. arboreum (illus. p.125). Evergreen, treelike rhododendron. H to 40ft (12m), S 10ft (3m). Undersides of broadly lance-shaped leaves are silver, fawn, or cinnamon. In spring, produces dense

clusters of bell-shaped flowers in colors ranging from red (most tender form) through pink to white. Z4–8

R. argyrophyllum. Evergreen, spreading rhododendron. H and S to 15ft (5m). Oblong leaves are silvery-white on undersides. Loose trusses of bell-shaped, rich pink flowers, sometimes with deeper colored spots, are borne in spring. Ideal for a light woodland. Z5–9
R. arizelum. syn. *R. rex* subsp. *arizelum*. Evergreen, bushy rhododendron. H and S 25ft (8m). Has deep green obovate leaves with cinnamon undersides. Flowers are usually yellow, sometimes pink, rarely white, with crimson-marked throats. Z5–8
R. ‘Ascot Brilliant’. Evergreen, bushy rhododendron. H and S 10ft (3m). Leaves are broadly ovate. In spring, produces loose trusses of funnel-shaped, waxy, rose-red blooms with darker edges. Z5–9
R. augustinii (illus. p.125). Evergreen, bushy rhododendron. H and S to 12ft (4m). Has small, lance-shaped to oblong, light green leaves and, in spring, bears an abundance of multi-stemmed, widely funnel-shaped, pale to deep blue or lavender flowers. Z6–10
R. auriculatum. Evergreen, bushy, widely branching rhododendron. H and S to 20ft (6m). Has large, oblong, hairy leaves with distinct, earlike lobes at their base. In late summer, bears loose trusses of 7–15 large, heavily scented, tubular to funnel-shaped, white flowers. Best in light woodland. Z5–9
R. ‘Azor’. Evergreen, upright rhododendron. H and S to 12ft (4m). Leaves are broadly ovate. Especially valuable as it produces large, fragrant, funnel-shaped, salmon-pink flowers in midsummer. Z5–9
R. ‘Azuma-kagami’. Evergreen, compact azalea. H and S 4ft (1.2m). Bears many small, hose-in-hose, deep pink flowers in mid-spring. Best in partial shade. Z5–9
R. barbatum. Evergreen, upright rhododendron. H and S to 30ft (10m). Bears lance-shaped, dark green leaves covered with bristles, on stems; bark is plum-colored and peeling. Bears tight trusses of tubular to bell-shaped, bright scarlet flowers in early spring. Z5–9
R. ‘Beauty of Littleworth’. Evergreen, open, shrubby rhododendron. H and S 12ft (4m). In late spring, bears large, conical trusses of scented, funnel-shaped, crimson-spotted, white flowers. Z8–9
R. ‘Beefeater’. Evergreen, bushy rhododendron. H and S to 8ft (2.5m). Leaves are broadly lance-shaped. Produces striking, flat-topped trusses of bell-shaped, scarlet flowers in late spring and early summer. Z5–9
R. ‘Blaauw’s Pink’ (illus. p.125). Evergreen, compact azalea. H and S 5ft (1.5m). In late spring, bears abundant, hose-in-hose, salmon-pink flowers, with a paler blush. Z8–10
R. ‘Blue Danube’ (illus. p.125). Evergreen, upright azalea. H 6ft (2m), S 5ft (1.5m). Produces bell-shaped, vivid violet-blue flowers in spring. Z9–11
R. ‘Blue Diamond’. Evergreen, upright rhododendron. H and S to 5ft (1.5m). Small, neat leaves contrast with funnel-shaped, bright purplish-blue flowers borne in mid- to late spring. Prefers full sun. Z6–8
R. ‘Blue Peter’ (illus. p.125). Evergreen, bushy rhododendron. H and S to 12ft (4m).

In early summer, produces bold, open funnel-shaped, 2-tone lavender-purple flowers, with frilled petal margins. Z6–8
R. calendulaceum (Flame azalea). Deciduous, bushy azalea. H and S 6–10ft (2–3m). In early summer, bears funnel-shaped, scarlet or orange flowers in trusses of 5–7. Z6–8
R. calophytum. Evergreen, widely branched rhododendron. H and S to 20ft (6m). Produces large, lance-shaped leaves and, in early spring, large trusses of bell-shaped, white or pale pink flowers, with crimson spots. Z5–9
R. calostrotum. Evergreen, compact rhododendron. H and to 3ft (1m). Has small blue-green leaves and, in late spring, bears saucer-shaped, purple or scarlet flowers in clusters of 2–5. Z6–8
R. ‘Catawbiense Album’. Evergreen, rounded rhododendron. H and S to 10ft (3m). Bears glossy leaves and, in early summer, dense, rounded trusses of bell-shaped, white flowers. Z4–8
R. ‘Catawbiense Boursault’. Evergreen, rounded rhododendron. H and S to 10ft (3m). Has glossy leaves. Bears dense, rounded trusses of bell-shaped, lilac-purple blooms in early summer. Z4–8
R. ‘Cilpinense’. Semievergreen, compact rhododendron. H and S to 5ft (1.5m). Leaves are dark green and glossy. Bears abundant, large, bell-shaped, blush-pink flowers, flushed deeper in bud, in early spring. Flowers are vulnerable to frost damage. Z5–9
R. cinnabarinum (illus. p.125). Evergreen, upright rhododendron. H and S 12ft (1.5–4m). Has blue-green leaves with small scales. Narrowly tubular, waxy, red, sometimes yellow, orange, apricot-pink or reddish purple flowers are borne in loose, pendent trusses in late spring. Z5–9.
subsp. xanthocodon (syn. *R. xanthocodon*) is of open, upright habit and has aromatic, mid-green leaves, which are blue-green when young. Bears bell-shaped, yellow flowers in late spring.
R. ‘Coccineum Speciosum’. Deciduous, bushy azalea. H and S 5–8ft (1.5–2.5m). Produces open funnel-shaped, brilliant rich orange-red blooms in early summer. Broadly lance-shaped leaves provide good fall color. Z6–8
R. ‘Corneille’. Deciduous, bushy azalea. H and S 5–8ft (1.5–2.5m). In early summer, produces fragrant, hose-in-hose flowers, pale pink with a darker pink outside. Has colorful fall foliage. Z6–8
R. ‘Crest’. syn. *R. ‘Hawk Crest’.* Evergreen rhododendron of open habit. H and S 5–12ft (1.5–4m). Has broadly lance-shaped leaves. Bell-shaped flowers are borne in loose, flat-topped trusses, and are apricot in bud, opening to clear sulphur-yellow in late spring. Z5–9
R. ‘Cunningham’s White’. Evergreen, compact rhododendron. H 8ft (2.5m), S 6ft (2m). In spring, has open trusses of funnel-shaped, pale lilac flowers, which fade to white, speckled with purple and yellow. Z6–8
R. ‘Curlew’ (illus. p.125). Evergreen rhododendron of compact, spreading habit. H and S 1ft (30cm). Has dull green leaves and, in late spring, produces relatively large, open funnel-shaped, bright yellow flowers. Z5–9
R. ‘Cynthia’. Vigorous, evergreen, dome-shaped rhododendron. H and S to 20ft

(6m). Bears conical trusses of bell-shaped, magenta-purple flowers, marked blackish-red within, in late spring. Excellent for sun or shade. Z6–8
R. dauricum. Deciduous, upright rhododendron. H and S to 5ft (1.5m). Bears funnel-shaped, vivid purple flowers in loose clusters throughout winter. Green leaves turn purple-brown in frosty conditions, before falling in fall. Z6–8
R. davidsonianum. Deciduous, upright rhododendron. H 5–12ft (1.5–4m). Aromatic leaves are lance-shaped to oblong. In late spring, bears clusters of funnel-shaped flowers, ranging from pale pink to mid-lilac-mauve. Z5–9
R. ‘Daviesii’ (illus. p.125). Deciduous, upright azalea. H and S 6ft (2m). Fragrant, funnel-shaped, white flowers, each with a yellow flare, are borne in spring. Z6–8
R. decorum (illus. p.124). Evergreen, bushy rhododendron. H and S 12ft (4m). Oblong to lance-shaped leaves are mid-green above, paler beneath. Large, fragrant, funnel-shaped, white or shell-pink flowers, green- or pink-spotted within, are produced in early summer. Z6–8
R. degronianum subsp. heptamerum. syn. *R. metternichii*. Evergreen, upright rhododendron. H and S 5–12ft (1.5–4m). Has oblong leaves, glossy and green above, reddish-brown-felted beneath. In spring, bears rounded trusses of 10–15 bell-shaped, rose-red flowers, often subtly spotted within. Z6–8
R. discolor. See *R. fortunei* subsp. *discolor*.
R. ‘Doncaster’. Evergreen, compact rhododendron. H and S 6–8ft (2–2.5m). Has leathery, glossy leaves and, in late spring, produces dense trusses of funnel-shaped, dark red flowers. Z6–8
R. ‘Dopey’. Evergreen, compact rhododendron. H and S 5ft (1.5m). In spring, bears rounded trusses of bell-shaped, flame-orange flowers. Z5–9
R. ‘Dora Amateis’. Evergreen, compact rhododendron. H and S 2ft (60cm). Leaves are slender, glossy and pointed. Abundant, broadly funnel-shaped, white flowers, tinged pink and marked with green, are produced in late spring. Sun tolerant. Z6–8
R. ‘Elizabeth’. Evergreen, dome-shaped rhododendron. H and S to 5ft (1.5m). Leaves are oblong. Produces trusses of large, trumpet-shaped, brilliant red flowers in late spring. Good in sun or partial shade. Z6–8
R. ‘Elizabeth Lockhart’. Evergreen, dome-shaped rhododendron. H and S 2ft (60cm). Produces shiny, purple-green leaves that become darker in winter. Bell-shaped, cherry red flowers are borne in spring. Z6–8
R. ‘English Roseum’. Evergreen, vigorous, bushy rhododendron. H and S to 8ft (2.5m). Dark green leaves are paler beneath. Bears compact trusses of funnel-shaped, lilac-rose flowers in late spring. Z4–8
R. ‘Fabia’. Evergreen, dome-shaped rhododendron. H and S 6ft (2m). Leaves are mid-green and lance-shaped. Produces loose, flat trusses of funnel-shaped, orange-tinted, scarlet flowers in early summer. Z7–9
R. falconeri (illus. p.124). Multi-stemmed, evergreen rhododendron. H to 40ft (12m),